FileSquid Design Guide

Complete visual language for light and dark mode — colours, typography, components, and voice. Toggle between modes above to preview all tokens live.

FOUNDATION

Design Philosophy

Principled minimalism with a playful soul. The FileSquid identity uses almost no decoration — what remains is clean space, a single bold green, and a friendly squid that carries all the personality the palette withholds. Every mode, light or dark, follows the same rules: flat fills, no gradients, no drop shadows, one accent colour per screen section.

> **The brand green (#16AC49) never changes between modes.** It is the one constant — primary button, active state, logo body, accent link — in both light and dark. Everything else adapts; the green holds.

VALUE	LIGHT MODE EXPRESSION	DARK MODE EXPRESSION
Local-first	White ground — grounded, not cloud-like	Near-black ground — same grounded quality
Ownership	Large serif headings, authoritative black	Same headings in near-white — same authority
Portability	Simple single-accent palette, easy to port	Same palette, surface tokens swapped only
Trust	No persuasion tricks, no urgency colours	No neon, no glows — same restraint

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COLOUR SYSTEM

Colour Palette

BRAND ACCENT BOTH MODES

Brand Green

`#16AC49`

Primary CTA · active states · logo · accent links. Identical in both modes.

BACKGROUND & SURFACE SCALE

☀ LIGHT MODE

Page background

`#FFFFFF`

Single flat surface — no layers

Raised / code bg

`#F5F5F5`

Inline chips, placeholder fills

DARK MODE

#141414
Page bg

#1C1C1C
Card / sidebar

#242424
Raised / hover

#2C2C2C
Overlay / modal

TEXT SCALE

ROLE	LIGHT MODE	DARK MODE
Heading (H1–H3)	`#000000`	`#F5F5F5`
Body text	`#111111`	`#E0E0E0` — not pure white; reduces dazzle

ROLE	LIGHT MODE	DARK MODE
Secondary / meta	`#555555`	`#A0A0A0`
Muted / eyebrows	`#777777`	`#6A6A6A`
Placeholder	`#999999`	`#6A6A6A`
Link / ghost button	`#16AC49`	`#16AC49` — unchanged

BORDER & DIVIDER

ROLE	LIGHT MODE	DARK MODE
Subtle (card outlines, nav)	`#E0E0E0`	`#2A2A2A`
Default (form inputs, tables)	`#CCCCCC`	`#333333`
Focus	`#16AC49`	`#16AC49`
Error	`#E53935`	`#EF5350` — brightened for dark bg

STATUS & SEMANTIC

ROLE	LIGHT MODE	DARK MODE
Active tag / sidebar background	`#F0FAF4`	`#0D2B18`
Active tag / sidebar text	`#0f8a39`	`#4ACA74` — lightened for contrast
Code chip background	`#F5F5F5`	`#1C1C1C`
Error (text + border)	`#E53935`	`#EF5350`

LOGO ACCENT TRI-COLOUR

BOTH MODES — UNCHANGED

These appear only in the squid logo SVG and file-type badges — never as UI colours (not buttons, alerts, or status indicators).

File-type Red

`#FD1E23`

Square in logo · document badges

File-type Yellow

`#FCD805`

Triangle in logo · data badges

File-type Blue

`#007AF9`

Circle in logo · media badges

TYPOGRAPHY

Typography

System fonts throughout — no web font load. Headings use a system serif; body uses system sans. Only colour tokens change between modes; all sizing, weight, and spacing rules are identical.

FONT STACKS

ROLE	STACK
Headings (serif)	`Georgia, 'Charter', 'Palatino Linotype', serif`
Body & UI (sans)	`-apple-system, BlinkMacSystemFont, 'Segoe UI', Roboto, Helvetica, Arial, sans-serif`
Code & technical	`'SF Mono', 'Fira Code', 'Fira Mono', 'Roboto Mono', 'Consolas', monospace`

TYPE SCALE

LEVEL	SIZE	WEIGHT	NOTES
H1	48–64px	700	Sentence case · lh 1.05 · letter-spacing –0.025em
H2	30–36px	700	Generous top margin
H3	20–24px	600	Feature / card titles
Body	17–18px	400	lh 1.65 · max column ~680px
Small / meta	13–14px	400	Muted colour
Eyebrow	11–12px	400	Uppercase · letter-spacing 0.1em · muted colour
Code chip	13–15px	400	Monospace · colour-token bg

LEVEL	SIZE	WEIGHT	NOTES
Button	14–16px	600	Sentence case only — never all-caps

LIVE SPECIMENS

H1 · GEORGIA 700 · ~52PX

Your files. Private.

H2 · GEORGIA 700 · ~32PX

Leave any service and keep the whole story

H3 · GEORGIA 600 · ~21PX

Local-first and offline

BODY · 17PX · LH 1.65

Your library lives on your machine and works without a connection.
Optional hosting and sync add convenience, never dependence.

SECONDARY / META · 13PX

In development. Open source under the MIT licence.

EYEBROW · 11PX · TRACKED · UPPERCASE

HOW IT WORKS

MONOSPACE CODE CHIPS

`OCFL` `C2PA` `PROV-O` `Dublin Core`

BRAND

Logo & Brand Mark

The FileSquid logo is a green semicircular squid head with black tentacles whose rounded tips reach into three shapes: a red square, a yellow triangle, and a blue circle. The wordmark "FileSquid" and the tentacle outline are a single flat black path. It is always flat vector: no gradients, no drop shadows, no 3D.

LOGO VARIANTS BY BACKGROUND







LOGO RULES

RULE	DETAIL
Squid head colour	`#16AC49` always (or white on a green background)
Three shapes	Always red / yellow / blue — never recoloured
Tentacles & wordmark	Black (`#000000`) on light · white (`#FFFFFF`) on dark — single combined path
Effects	No drop shadows, glows, gradients, or 3D — ever, in either mode. The black path (tentacles + wordmark) is a single `fill-rule:evenodd` shape.
Minimum size	24px tall (digital)
Clear space	Equal to the height of the squid's head on all sides

LAYOUT

Layout & Spacing

Grid, column widths, and spacing are identical in both modes. Only surface tokens change.

GRID

SETTING	VALUE
Max page width	1100–1200px, centred
Prose / content column	680–720px max

SETTING	VALUE
Product sidebar width	240px (left navigation)
Detail panel width	320px max (right context panel)
Side margins (mobile)	16–24px

DARK MODE: ELEVATION REPLACES WHITESPACE

In light mode a single white surface separates content with space and borders. In dark mode a four-step surface scale does the same job — no box-shadows.

Base #141414
Page background

Card #1C1C1C
Sidebar, cards, panels

Raised #242424
Hover, dropdown, tooltip

Overlay #2C2C2C
Modal content

8PX SPACING SCALE

4px	8px	16px	24px	40px	64px	96px
space-1	space-2	space-3	space-4	space-5	space-6	space-7

COMPONENTS

UI Components

BUTTONS

Import files Learn more View on GitHub Delete

VARIANT	LIGHT BG / TEXT	DARK BG / TEXT	BORDER
Primary	`#16AC49` / white	`#16AC49` / white — unchanged	none
Secondary	`#FFFFFF` / `#111111`	`#1C1C1C` / `#E0E0E0`	1.5px muted
Ghost	transparent / `#16AC49`	transparent / `#16AC49`	none
Destructive	white / `#E53935`	`#1C1C1C` / `#EF5350`	1.5px error

TAGS, BADGES & CHIPS

Active Version 3 OCFL C2PA MIT

File badges: PDF JPG CSV MP4 DOCX

FILE CARD

Preview · raised surface

meeting-notes.pdf PDF

Added 14 Oct 2026

FORM INPUTS

Import source

Path or URL

Import source (focused)

~/Documents/Photos

Import source (error)

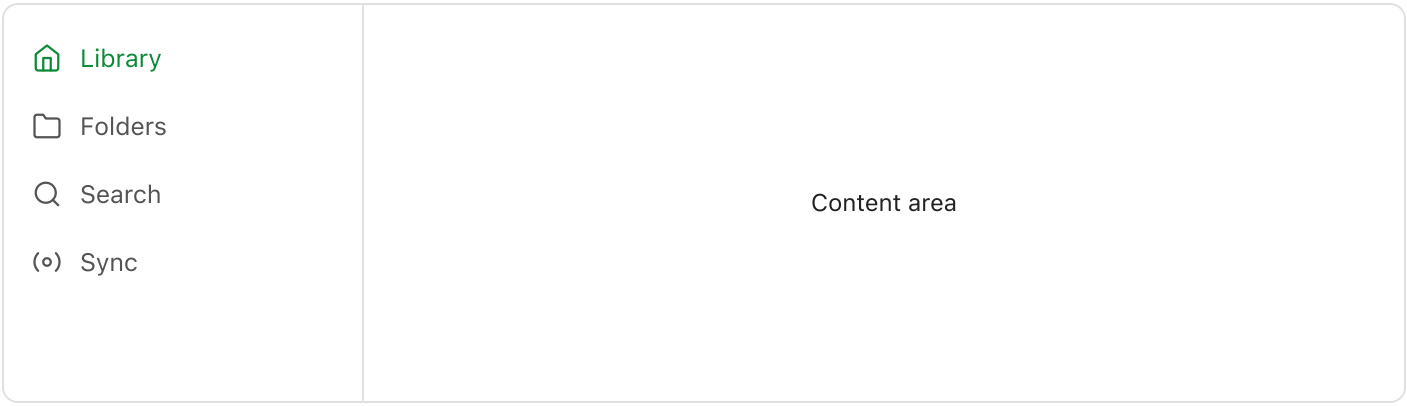
/invalid/path

The folder could not be read.

NAVIGATION BAR

FileSquid Why How it works Distributions

SIDEBAR NAVIGATION (PRODUCT UI)



ICONOGRAPHY

Iconography & Illustration

ICON STYLE

PROPERTY	SPEC
Style	Line icons, 1.5–2px stroke, rounded caps/joins. No fill. (Lucide or Heroicons)
Size grid	16px · 20px · 24px (standard) · 32px (feature callouts)
Default colour	Light: `#111111` · Dark: `#A0A0A0`
Active colour	`#16AC49` — identical both modes
Muted colour	Light: `#777777` · Dark: `#6A6A6A`
Disabled	Light: `#CCCCCC` · Dark: `#3A3A3A`

ILLUSTRATION PRINCIPLES

The squid logo sets the illustration DNA. Any future onboarding or empty-state artwork follows the same rules in both modes: flat vector, closed fills, solid colours, minimal detail, no gradients, no 3D. Squid body stays `#16AC49` always. Never add glows or neon effects for a "dark mode feel".

MOTION

Motion & Interaction

Motion rules are identical in both modes. **Purposeful and invisible** — transitions orient, never entertain.

TYPE	DURATION	EASING
Micro (hover, focus ring)	80–120ms	`ease-out`
Component (dropdown, panel)	150–200ms	`ease-in-out`
Page / large panel	250–300ms	`cubic-bezier(0.4, 0, 0.2, 1)`
Never	>400ms	—

> Always respect `prefers-reduced-motion` — all transitions are disabled or reduced to instant when the OS setting is active. This applies equally to both modes.

COPY

Voice & Tone

Voice and tone rules apply identically across both modes and all surfaces.

KEY CHARACTERISTICS

PRINCIPLE	IN PRACTICE
Direct and plain	"Your library lives on your machine" — not "Experience seamless offline access"
Active voice	Subject → verb → object. Sentences under 20 words.
Sentence case always	Headlines, buttons, labels, nav items — never title case or ALL CAPS
British/international English	organisation, licence (n), behaviour, colour
Technically literate	Standards named and briefly explained (OCFL, C2PA, Dublin Core)
Honest	"In development" stated plainly. No vaporware language.

WORDS TO AVOID

Seamless · powerful · robust · cutting-edge · unlock (as metaphor) · simply · just · exclamation marks in success states · "Please" in errors · manage (when a more specific verb exists)

QUICK REFERENCE

Do / Don't

COLOUR — LIGHT MODE

✓ DO

- ✓ Use `#16AC49` for the single primary action
- ✓ Keep all backgrounds white (`#FFFFFF`)
- ✓ Use flat fills only — no gradients ever
- ✓ Keep tri-colour in logo / file badges only

✕ DON'T

- ✕ Use green on more than one button per screen
- ✕ Use off-white or grey page backgrounds
- ✕ Add drop shadows for elevation
- ✕ Use red / yellow / blue as alert or status colours

COLOUR — DARK MODE

✓ DO

- ✓ Use `#141414` as page background
- ✓ Step surfaces lighter: card → raised → overlay
- ✓ Use `#E0E0E0` for body text (not white)
- ✓ Use `#EF5350` for errors (brightened)

✕ DON'T

- ✕ Use pure `#000000` — reads as a void
- ✕ Add glows, neon, or gradient washes
- ✕ Use `#FFFFFF` body text — too much dazzle
- ✕ Add shadows — invisible on dark and add noise

TYPOGRAPHY

✓ DO

- ✓ Sentence case everywhere
- ✓ H1 at ≥48px, large and confident
- ✓ Body columns max ~680px wide
- ✓ Monospace for all technical terms & code

✕ DON'T

- ✕ Use title case or all-caps on buttons
- ✕ Shrink headings to fit more content
- ✕ Let body text run full-width on large screens
- ✕ Render standard names (OCFL, C2PA) in body type

BRAND & LOGO

✓ DO

- ✓ Squid body always `#16AC49` (or white on green)
- ✓ White wordmark on dark backgrounds
- ✓ Keep all three shape colours fixed
- ✓ Minimum 24px tall in digital use

✕ DON'T

- ✕ Recolour or add effects to the logo
- ✕ Use the black wordmark on dark backgrounds
- ✕ Add glows to the logo in dark mode
- ✕ Stretch, rotate, or distort the mark

DARK MODE COMMON MISTAKES

The neon trap — adding bright or glowing colours because dark mode "allows" them. FileSquid's dark palette is as restrained as its light palette.

The inversion trap — simply applying `filter: invert()`. This breaks the green and destroys the brand.

The pure black trap — `#000000` backgrounds feel oppressive and make any near-black element look grey.

> **The shadow trap** — drop shadows are nearly invisible on dark surfaces and add visual noise. Use surface steps instead.